

Earned media plays a critical role in AI search rankings because AI search engines heavily favor trusted, reputable sources 1, 2. In fact, earned content accounts for up to **89% of all AI search citations** 3.

Here is a breakdown of how earned media influences AI visibility:

- **Prioritization of Authority:** AI tools are designed to surface high-authority sources, such as established media outlets (e.g., Bloomberg, Fortune, and Forbes) and analyst reports 1, 2. Securing coverage in these premium publications directly improves a brand's likelihood of being recommended in AI-powered search results 2.
- **LLM Partnerships:** A major new strategic factor for marketers is whether a media outlet has established direct data partnerships with Large Language Models (LLMs) 4. For example, publications like *The Washington Post* and the *Financial Times* partner with OpenAI, while *The Independent* partners with Perplexity 4. Giving exclusive stories to these specific outlets significantly boosts the chances of a brand's narrative feeding directly into AI answers 4, 5.
- **Driving Strategic Investment:** Because AI search engines prioritize these trusted sources, B2B tech companies are adapting their PR strategies. Approximately 32% of tech CMOs are planning to increase their PR budgets specifically to strengthen their presence in high-authority media and analyst reports to optimize for AI visibility 1, 6.